

Q Will I know when I'm about to go into labor? Are there signs, and what should I do if I experience them?

When you are very close to true first stage labor, there are three signs that could appear. It's not guaranteed that you will see them all—some women skip them entirely—but if you do, you should inform your doctor.

It is natural to be concerned about recognizing the signs of early labor—unsurprisingly, it is a common worry among pregnant women—but the truth is your experience can be quite different from the next woman's. While the symptoms described below do indicate that labor is imminent, for some women active labor (see p.205) could still be a couple of days away, especially if this is their first pregnancy. Getting a

“bloody show” or the first labor contractions indicates that your cervix has started to soften and thin (known as “effacement”) in order to open and allow your baby to pass through the birth canal. The length of time this takes can vary greatly, so listen to your body and time your contractions. If your water breaks, it mostly does so once contractions have started; if it happens beforehand for you, call your doctor.

SIGNS OF IMMINENT LABOR

	SYMPTOMS	HOW SOON WILL I MEET MY BABY?	ACTION
A “bloody show” (dislodging of the cervical mucus plug)	A brownish or yellowish vaginal discharge, your mucus plug has a jellylike consistency and may look like congealed, yellowed phlegm, or be tinged dark brown with blood. It may come away in one “blob” or several. Some women never have a show; others pass the plug without noticing while going to the bathroom.	Even though the dislodging of the mucus plug is a sure sign that your cervix is opening, active labor could still be a few days away, or even weeks if this is your first baby.	Call your doctor. You will probably be advised to have a relaxing bath or otherwise try to distract yourself, and to look out for first contractions. However, if you have any bright red bleeding, you are feeling unwell, or the baby has not been moving, call your doctor right away.
Labor contractions	Painful, periodlike cramps that begin in the upper portion of your abdomen and spread downward. Contractions may be irregular and spaced fairly far apart at first, becoming more regularly spaced and lasting for one to two minutes each.	These “latent-phase” contractions could indicate that “active labor” is only a few hours (or less) away, but in some cases contractions will be slow and last a few days (at most).	Call your doctor. If you're going to a hospital to give birth, they will probably ask you to stay at home as long as you feel you can. If you experience any bleeding or your water breaks, call your doctor and go to the hospital.
Water breaking (rupture of membranes)	This may happen as a gush or a trickle—amniotic fluid looks a lot like pale urine, so you may think you have stress incontinence.	Your baby's arrival may still be a few days away, but now that the amniotic sac has broken, your baby is at risk of infection, so will need to be delivered sooner rather than later.	Call your doctor immediately for advice. Since your baby is now at risk of infection, you will need to be carefully monitored. You should not lie in a bath, in case of infection. If the amniotic fluid is greenish in color, go to the hospital right away (it could be meconium, a fetal bowel movement).

Q I have a “bloody show.” Does this mean I'm in the first stage of labor?

If the show is accompanied by irregular contractions, yes, you are probably in the first “latent” stage. However, by itself, losing your mucus plug is not an indication that the first stage of labor has started, it's simply a sign that things are moving in the right direction. It's definitely time to start watching out for more certain labor signs, especially contractions that build in intensity over time.

Q I think I'm in early labor and I feel sick. Should I eat?

Eating is discouraged even in the beginning stages of labor. Though some doctors may allow women to eat light snacks in the first stage of labor, the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (ACOG) recommends that you do not eat at all while in labor. Women laboring in hospitals are usually offered only ice chips to suck on instead of water to drink and no food at all. Recently, however, the guidelines

from the ACOG changed a bit. Instead of only ice chips, it's now believed to be OK for moms-to-be, who are having uncomplicated labors, to drink small amounts of clear liquids such as water, fruit juices without pulp (though the acidity of orange juice may upset your stomach), carbonated beverages, clear tea, black coffee, sports drinks, and clear broth.

The restriction on eating during labor comes from the theory that food could be breathed in (aspirated) during an emergency surgery in the unlikely event you would need to have general anesthesia.